

Minimum Viable Product (MVP)

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The smallest solution that starts the build–measure–learn loop

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

An MVP is the smallest, cheapest version of a product that lets a team begin the **build–measure–learn** loop with real users and validated learning. It is not a smaller product but a learning device: the least you can build to test your riskiest assumption.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Popularised by Eric Ries in *The Lean Startup* (2011), drawing on Steve Blank's customer-development method.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Startups waste resources building full products nobody wants. The MVP minimises time and cost to first validated learning, so teams pivot or persevere on evidence.

HOW IT IS USED

Identify the riskiest assumption, build the minimum needed to test it (which may be a landing page or concierge service, not code), measure real behaviour, and learn.

WHEN IT IS USED

Prototyping and early validation, before scaling a build.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, product managers and innovation teams.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It reframes the prototype as an **experiment** rather than a draft product, embedding scientific method into product development.

FIGURE 1 · BUILD – MEASURE – LEARN

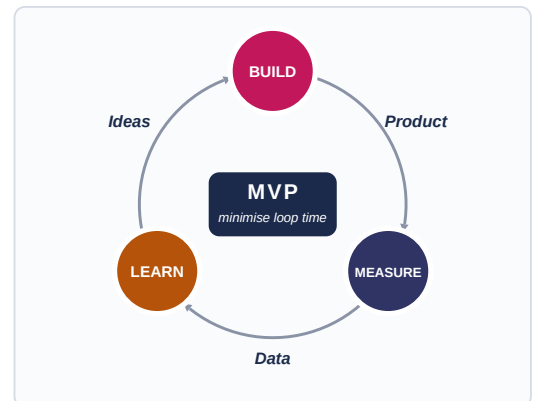


Figure 1. The MVP is the smallest build that completes one Build–Measure–Learn loop and yields validated learning.

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Critical Items Diagram *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Ries, E. (2011) *The Lean Startup*. New York: Crown Business.

Blank, S. (2013) 'Why the Lean Start-Up Changes Everything', *Harvard Business Review*, 91(5), pp. 63–72.